NORTHSTAR DIGITAL SERVICES LTD.

People Operations · Finance · Information Security

Hybrid and Flexible Working Standard

Hybrid attendance, flexible-working requests and working abroad

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Revision history — NDS-HR-HFW-005

Version	Date	Summary of changes
1.0	1 January 2025	Original hybrid standard (3 office days per week).
1.1	1 October 2026	8 days per rolling 4 weeks; Work From Abroad limit 10 working days; new owner.

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1 Purpose, scope and status

1.1 Purpose

This Hybrid and Flexible Working Standard (NDS-HR-HFW-005, version 1.1) is the authoritative rule for hybrid working, remote contracts, statutory flexible-working requests, temporary arrangements and working from outside the UK. It expands section 10 of the Employee Handbook NDS-HR-HB-001 v2.0.

1.2 Scope

This Standard applies to all employees. Contractors and agency workers follow the working-location terms in their engagement, but must comply with section 9 (remote-working security) and the IT Security, Data Protection and Generative AI Policy NDS-SEC-ITG-004 whenever they work away from a Northstar office.

1.3 Status

Effective from **1 October 2026**, replacing version 1.0 (effective 1 January 2025 to 30 September 2026), which is not part of the current document set. Owner: **Head of Workplace Experience** (workplace@northstar.example). Approved by: Director of People Operations. Next review: 1 October 2027.

2 Types of arrangement

Table 2.1 — Decision table: which arrangement applies?

Feature	Routine home-working day	Temporary arrangement	Formal flexible-working request	Permanent relocation or remote contract	Temporarily working from another country
Example	Working from home on a non-anchor day within the team pattern	Starting at 11:00 for 8 weeks during a parent's recovery from surgery	Moving to a 4-day compressed week permanently	Moving from Manchester to Bristol and becoming remote-contracted	Working from Portugal for 5 days after a holiday
Contractual change?	No	No	Yes, once confirmed (unless a trial)	Yes	No
Who approves	No approval needed if within the team pattern; tell the team	Line manager	Line manager; appeal to a more senior manager	Head of Department and People Operations	Line manager, People Operations and IT Security
Notice or timescale	None	Agree in advance where possible	Decision, including any appeal, within 2 months of the request	Normally at least 2 months before the move	Request at least 4 weeks before travel
Record	PeopleHub location status	PeopleHub temporary arrangement with end date	PeopleHub flexible-working case; written variation	Contract variation letter	PeopleHub Work From Abroad request
Key limits	Minimum 8 office days per rolling 4-week period	Up to 6 months; attendance below standard for more than 4 weeks needs an attendance exception (section 12)	2 statutory requests per 12 months	UK only	10 working days per rolling 12 months; no Restricted data without CISO approval

3 Role designations and eligibility

Table 3.1 — Role designations

Designation	Meaning	Examples
Office-based	Work requires presence at a Northstar office on most working days.	Service desk hardware technicians, facilities staff.
Hybrid	Combination of office or customer site and home working, subject to the attendance standard.	Most engineering, consulting, sales, finance and HR roles.
Remote (contractual)	Contractual workplace is the employee's home in the UK; attendance at an office is occasional.	Roles advertised as remote; employees approved under section 6.

Hybrid working is available from the first day of employment in hybrid roles. During the first **4 weeks** of employment, new starters in hybrid roles attend at least **3 days per week** to complete induction. Employees in probation cannot work from abroad (section 7).

4 Office attendance standard

4.1 The standard

Employees in hybrid roles attend a Northstar office, a customer site or an approved off-site team event on at least **8 days in each rolling 4-week period** (equivalent to 2 days per week). Each team agrees one or two **anchor days** per week in a team charter, reviewed every 6 months.

4.2 What counts

Table 4.2 — What counts towards the attendance standard

Location or activity	Counts?	Notes
Any Northstar office (Manchester, Leeds or London hub)	Yes	Recorded by access card.
Customer site for a working day	Yes	Record "Customer site" in PeopleHub.
Approved off-site team event or training course	Yes	Record "Off-site" in PeopleHub.
Co-working space	Only if approved by the Head of Department for a specific reason	—
Working from home	No	—
Business travel day without attending a site	No	—

4.3 Part-time employees and absence

The requirement is pro-rated and rounded **up** to the nearest whole day:

- **Part-time:** required days = 8 x (contracted working days per week / 5). For a 3-day week: 8 x 3 / 5 = 4.8, rounded up to **5 days** per rolling 4-week period.
- **Annual leave, sickness, bank holidays and other approved absence:** required days = (normal requirement) x (available working days in the period / normal working days in the period). For a full-time employee with 5 days of annual leave in a 4-week period of 20 working days: 8 x 15 / 20 = **6 days**.

4.4 Monitoring

Attendance is reviewed by line managers in one-to-ones using access-card data and PeopleHub location records. Attendance data is not used for automated decisions. Where an employee falls short of the standard for **3 consecutive** 4-week periods without an agreed reason, the manager holds a supportive conversation to understand the reasons and consider adjustments, an attendance exception or a flexible-working request. Only a persistent, unexplained refusal to follow a reasonable instruction after that conversation may be treated as a conduct matter.

5 Formal flexible-working requests

5.1 Eligibility

Every employee may make a statutory flexible-working request from their first day of employment, and may make up to **2 statutory requests in any 12-month period**. Contractors and agency workers cannot use this procedure.

5.2 Procedure

Table 5.2 — Flexible-working procedure and deadlines

Step	Action	Deadline
1	Employee submits the PeopleHub "Statutory flexible working request" form, stating it is a statutory request, the date, the pattern requested and proposed start date, and any previous request and its date.	—
2	Line manager acknowledges the request.	Within 5 working days of receipt
3	Line manager meets the employee to discuss the request and possible alternatives. The employee may be accompanied by a colleague or trade union representative.	Within 4 weeks of receipt
4	Written decision: approve, approve with modifications or a trial, or refuse with the statutory reasons explained.	In time to allow any appeal within the 2-month period
5	Employee may appeal in writing.	Within 10 working days of the decision
6	Appeal heard by a more senior manager not involved in the original decision; written appeal outcome.	Within the 2-month period, unless the employee agrees an extension

The whole process, including any appeal, must be completed within **2 months** of the date the request was received, unless the employee agrees to extend it. If the employee fails to attend two meetings without good reason, the request may be treated as withdrawn, and the employee is told this in writing.

5.3 Refusal reasons

A request may be refused only after consultation and only for one or more of these statutory business reasons: the burden of additional costs; inability to reorganise work among existing staff; inability to recruit additional staff; a detrimental impact on quality; a detrimental impact on performance; a detrimental effect on ability to meet customer demand; insufficient work during the periods the employee proposes to work; or planned structural changes. The decision letter must explain why the reason applies.

> **Future change to flexible working [legal review flag]**
> Under the Employment Rights Act 2025, employers will be required to show that refusing a request is reasonable on the stated grounds and to follow a prescribed consultation process. At the date of this Standard, these changes were expected during 2027 and had not commenced. Northstar already requires managers to consult and to explain why a refusal reason applies.

5.4 Trials and outcomes

Managers may agree a trial of up to **3 months**, recorded with a review date. At the end of the trial, the arrangement becomes permanent, is extended once by up to 3 months, or ends with reasons given. A permanent change is a contractual variation confirmed in writing by People Operations within 14 days.

5.5 Examples

- **Approved:** A G3 engineer requests a 9-day fortnight. The team can rearrange release-day cover. Approved for a 3-month trial, then made permanent.
- **Approved with modification:** An analyst asks to work 07:00 to 15:00 every day. The team's customer calls run until 16:00 on Tuesdays, so the manager approves 07:00 to 15:00 on four days and 08:30 to 16:30 on Tuesdays, with the employee's agreement.
- **Refused:** A service-desk technician asks to work fully remotely. Device handling at the Manchester office is required on 3 days a week and cannot be reorganised among the 2 other technicians. Refused for "inability to reorganise work among existing staff", with an alternative of 2 remote days offered.

6 Permanent relocation and remote contracts

- A request to change the contractual place of work (including becoming remote-contracted) is made as a statutory flexible-working request or as part of a role change, and is approved by the Head of Department and People Operations.
- The new contractual workplace must be in the **United Kingdom**. Northstar does not support permanent relocation outside the UK, because it has no overseas employing entities.
- Northstar does not change salary because an employee moves to a different part of the UK.
- Travel from a remote employee's home to a Northstar office is business travel only where the contract states that the home is the contractual workplace; otherwise it is commuting (NDS-FIN-EXP-003 section 4.3).
- Employees moving to Scotland or Northern Ireland must tell People Operations, because local policy review is needed (handbook section 1.8).

7 Working from outside the UK

7.1 Rules

Table 7.1 — Work From Abroad rules

Rule	Detail
Maximum	**10 working days** in any rolling 12-month period. Any working day on which any work is performed abroad counts as a full day.
Request	PeopleHub Work From Abroad request at least **4 weeks** before travel.
Approvals	Line manager, People Operations (tax, social security and immigration screening) and IT Security (destination and data check). All three are required.
Eligibility	Employees who have completed probation and are not serving notice.
Destinations	Not permitted to destinations on the IT Security restricted-destination list.
Data	Public, Internal and Confidential information may be accessed through Northstar Secure Connect. **Restricted** information must not be accessed unless the CISO has approved it in writing and the customer contract permits access from outside the UK.
Availability	The employee must be available for UK core hours (10:00 to 16:00 UK time).
Exceptions	More than 10 days requires Director of People Operations approval and external tax and immigration advice; no exception may exceed **20 working days** in a rolling 12-month period.
Business trips	Travel abroad at Northstar's request for customer or company work is a business trip under NDS-FIN-EXP-003 and does not count towards the 10 days.

7.2 Why the limits exist

Working abroad can create tax and social security liabilities for the employee and Northstar, may require a work permit or visa even for remote work, may give rise to local employment-law obligations, may not be covered by Northstar's insurance, and may breach customer contracts or data-protection requirements on international transfers. Employees are responsible for having the right to enter the country; People Operations' screening does not amount to immigration or tax advice to the individual.

7.3 Worked examples

Work From Abroad examples

- **Within the limit:** An employee who has not worked abroad in the past 12 months requests to work from Portugal for 5 working days in July 2027, submitting the request 6 weeks ahead. Approvable, subject to all three approvals.
- **Rolling limit exceeded:** An employee worked abroad for 6 days in February 2027 and asks for 5 days in October 2027. Within the rolling 12 months this would total 11 days, so only **4 days** can be approved unless the Director of People Operations approves an exception (maximum 20 days).
- **Restricted customer data:** An employee who supports a customer's payroll platform (Restricted data) asks to work from Italy for a week. They may work abroad only on tasks that do not involve Restricted data, unless the CISO approves in writing and the customer contract permits access from outside the UK. The manager arranges UK-based cover for Restricted tasks.
- **Short notice:** A request submitted 10 days before travel does not meet the 4-week notice requirement and will normally be declined.
- **Probation:** An employee in month 4 of probation asks to work from Spain for 3 days. Not eligible until probation is completed.
- **Holiday email:** An employee on annual leave in France briefly reads email on their phone. This is not a working day abroad. Joining a customer call or accessing customer systems would be, and requires approval.

8 Equipment

Table 8.1 — Equipment for hybrid and remote employees

Item	Provision
Laptop, monitor, keyboard, mouse, headset	Provided by IT; remain Northstar property; returned on leaving (handbook section 20.6).
Home office allowance	Up to **£300** (including VAT) once in any 3-year period after probation, through ExpenseFlow with receipts, for a desk, chair or ergonomic items.
Reasonable adjustment equipment	Provided through People Operations; does not count towards the allowance.
Broadband, utilities, phone	Not reimbursed.
Insurance	Northstar equipment is covered by Northstar's insurance; employees should tell their home insurer that they work from home.

9 Remote-working security

- Use Northstar Secure Connect (VPN) whenever not on a Northstar office network.
- Public Wi-Fi may be used only with Northstar Secure Connect active, and never for Restricted information.
- Do not work on Confidential or Restricted information where others can see your screen or hear your calls; use a privacy filter in public places.
- Do not print Confidential or Restricted information at home.
- Do not let family members or others use Northstar devices.
- Report lost or stolen equipment within 1 hour (handbook section 20.3).

10 Health and safety

Complete the PeopleHub DSE self-assessment within **2 weeks** of starting home working and when your set-up changes. Report accidents at home within 24 hours using the PeopleHub Safety form. Northstar may arrange an ergonomic assessment where the self-assessment identifies a concern.

11 Adjustments and caring responsibilities

Hybrid, remote and flexible arrangements can be reasonable adjustments for disabled employees. Requests linked to disability are considered under the duty to make reasonable adjustments in addition to, and not limited by, the statutory flexible-working procedure (including the 2-requests limit). Carers can use the flexible-working procedure, temporary arrangements and carer's leave (handbook section 8.8).

12 Temporary arrangements and attendance exceptions

- A line manager may agree a **temporary arrangement** of up to **6 months** changing hours, days or location within the UK. It is recorded in PeopleHub with an end date and ends automatically on that date unless extended in writing.
- A temporary arrangement may reduce office attendance below the 8-day standard for no more than **4 weeks**. A longer reduction is an **attendance exception**, approved by the Head of Department for up to 3 months or by the Director of People Operations for longer periods up to 12 months (handbook Table 23.1).
- Temporary arrangements and exceptions are not contractual and create no precedent.

13 Changing or revoking arrangements

- Team hybrid patterns and anchor days may be changed for genuine business reasons with at least **4 weeks' notice** (less in an emergency such as an office closure).
- An individual's hybrid arrangement may be varied after a documented conversation and at least 4 weeks' notice, for example where security requirements of a new customer require on-site work. Arrangements may be suspended immediately where there is a serious security breach while working remotely, pending investigation.
- Contractual flexible-working arrangements can be changed only by agreement, by a new statutory request, or after proper consultation.
- An employee who wishes to return to a previous pattern makes a new request.

14 Manager decision criteria

Managers must decide objectively, considering: the requirements of the role; team coverage and customer commitments; security and data classification of the work; any reasonable-adjustment duty; the effect on colleagues; and cost. Managers must not decide on the basis of personal preference, assumptions about caring responsibilities, or visibility in the office as a proxy for performance. Decisions and reasons are recorded in PeopleHub.

15 Version history

Table 15.1 — Version history, NDS-HR-HFW-005

Version	Effective	Summary
1.0	1 January 2025	Original hybrid standard: 3 office days per week; Work From Abroad up to 20 working days per year (not in current document set).
1.1	1 October 2026	Attendance standard changed to 8 days per rolling 4-week period; Work From Abroad reduced to 10 working days per rolling 12 months with IT Security approval; owner changed to Head of Workplace Experience.